(NCP), led by deputy chief minister Ajit Pawar, has expressed unease at the growing tide of majoritarian politics. Ajit Pawar has warned that those threatening Muslims will not be spared. NCP leaders say law-and-order disruptions do not bode well for the state at a time it is trying to attract investors. Congress leaders too assert that communal issues are being raked up to deflect attention from more critical matters such as farmers' suicides and unemployment.

The Hindutva Objectives

Hindutva advocates, however, dismiss accusations of stoking history for political gain. VHP president Alok Kumar is clear when he says, "There should be no glorification of Aurangzeb. He imprisoned his own father, brutally killed his own brothers...led large-scale conversions, desecrated temples. He can't be our hero." (See interview, *'Our focus is on Mathura and Kashi only'.*) Author Amish (see column *Time to Choose Our Heroes Wisely*), while acknowledging the historical significance of medieval Muslim rulers prefers that we "don't celebrate them".

Surprisingly, it is the RSS that has been advocating restraint. Following the construction of the Ram temple in Ayodhya, the RSS has been more nuanced in its strategy. It has warned the stormtroopers of the Sangh parivar not to engage in any illegal activity for correcting historical wrongs but to approach the courts for relief. Thus the Gyanvapi Masjid dispute in Varanasi, the Krishna Janmabhoomi-Shahi Idgah battle in Mathura and even the Shahi Jama Masjid campaign in Sambhal are being fought in the courts of law. It was the Supreme Court that permitted local officials to survey the Gyanvapi Masjid even though it upheld the Places of Worship Act. Sangh affiliates are now challenging the very constitutionality of the 1991 legislation and the apex court's decision is awaited. Back in 2022, RSS chief Mohan Bhagwat had also told "overenthusiastic" swayamsevaks not to look for shivlings under every mosque, as Sangh insiders feared such "overexuberance" would turn the entire Muslim community against them. When reminded of Bhagwat's statement, Alok Kumar interpreted it to mean "looking for shivlings where they are".

Meanwhile, in Nagpur, a week after the initial unrest, civic officials demolished the house of an accused in the riots. The Bombay High Court stayed the demolition of the properties of two persons accused of being involved in the violence and warned the administration to follow the due process of law for any such activity. Curfew was lifted six days after the violence, and a fragile peace hangs over the city beneath the looming cinematic backdrop of medieval bloodshed, and passions now projected in digital clarity, and the surround-sound clangour of political mobilisation. ■

–*with* Anilesh S. Mahajan, Amarnath K. Menon, Rohit Parihar, Ajay Sukumaran and Arkamoy Datta Majumdar



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